

P1498R1

Constrained Internal Linkage for Modules

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Abstract

We propose constraints on the use of internal linkage names within module interface units to make them both reliable and useful. This is intended to avoid the need of linkage promotion and its associated problems while preserving the simple, teachable utility of internal linkage such as being able to factor non-inline function definitions into internal helpers without any non-local effects.

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§ 1. Problem & Motivation

Internal linkage names for functions, variables, and types are routinely used to factor and express implementation details of C++ interfaces today, and this practice is useful and important for maintainability of this code. One consequence of introducing modules into C++ is that it easily allows embedding the implementation of an interface into a module's interface unit without these being exposed to the consumers of that interface unit. In effect, these implementation details remain local to the translation unit, despite this being a module interface unit. However, as currently specified, using internal linkage names for components of these implementation details creates problems because those names may also be used in ways that do *not* remain local to the translation unit.

§ 2. Proposal

The overarching principle is that internal linkage names may only be used within a context that is defined to remain local to the translation unit for importable translation units.

§ 2.1. Translation Unit Local

Some parts of a module interface unit do not escape that translation unit. We call these *translation unit local* or *TU-local*. The canonical example is a non-inline function definition. The contents of this definition have *no* visible effect beyond the translation unit. Our current understanding of the TU-local constructs in C++:

- Types, functions, and variables whose names have internal linkage (including those within anonymous namespaces)
- Types, functions, and variables whose names have no linkage

ISSUE 1 Local class member functions appear to have no linkage even when they occur within inline functions with external (or module) linkage. This seems like a bug generally, but certainly such member functions are **not** TU-local.

- Function definitions which are not inline, non-templated, and not `constexpr`
- Variable definitions which are not inline and non-templated
- Template specializations for which any template argument involves a TU-local entity
- Template (or nested with a template) type definitions, function definitions, and variable initializations for which implicit instantiation is precluded, perhaps through an explicit instantiations

Note: an explicit instantiation of a class template might not preclude implicit instantiation of some of its member function definitions!

TODO(all): Are there missing items from this list?

§ 2.2. Restrict Usage of Internal Linkage Names

We propose restricting the usage of an internal linkage name to TU-local contexts as defined above. This is not influenced by reachability making it both easy to check and easy to teach. It also matches the underlying use case of internal linkage names: organizing the implementation details of a translation unit. If they are implementation details, they should remain local.

We specifically mean to restrict *any* use except for the specific exception to ODR-use afforded for non-volatile const objects in [\[basic.def.odr\]p12.2.1](#).

Note: This stronger than ODR-use restriction is necessary to avoid forcing the creation of unique names even in contexts where no symbol reference is required. One example is referencing an internal linkage name from the signature of a function.

This restriction is only enforced for importable translation units which include module interface units, partition units, and header units. One specific advantage of this solution to the problems discovered with linkage promotion is that this rule can be consistently used across all importable units including header units. Non-importable units are discussed below.

§ 2.2.1. Examples with basic functions

```
1 export module M;  
2  
3 static constexpr int f() { return 0; }
```

...

```

10 static int f_internal() { return f(); } // OK
11     int f_module()     { return f(); } // OK
12 export int f_exported() { return f(); } // OK
13
14 static inline int f_internal_inline() { return f(); } // OK
15     inline int f_module_inline()     { return f(); } // ERROR
16 export inline int f_exported_inline() { return f(); } // ERROR
17
18 static constexpr int f_internal_constexpr() { return f(); } // OK
19     constexpr int f_module_constexpr()     { return f(); } // ERROR
20 export constexpr int f_exported_constexpr() { return f(); } // ERROR
21
22 static consteval int f_internal_consteval() { return f(); } // OK
23     consteval int f_module_consteval()     { return f(); } // ERROR
24 export consteval int f_exported_consteval() { return f(); } // ERROR
25
26 static decltype(f()) f_internal_decltype() { return 0; } // OK
27     decltype(f()) f_module_decltype()     { return 0; } // ERROR
28 export decltype(f()) f_exported_decltype() { return 0; } // ERROR

```

§ 2.2.2. Examples with basic templates

```

1 export module M;
2
3 static constexpr int f() { return 0; }

```

...

```

31 template <typename T> static int ft_internal() { return f(); } // OK
32 template <typename T>          int ft_module()   { return f(); } // ERROR
33 template <typename T> export int ft_exported() { return f(); } // ERROR
34 template <typename T>          int ftei_module() { return f(); } // OK for
35 template                      int ftei_module<int>();
36 template <typename T> export int ftei_exported() { return f(); } // OK for
37 template                      int ftei_exported<int>();
38
39 template <typename T> inline int ftei_module_inline() { return f(); } // OK
40 template                      int ftei_module_inline<int>();
41
42 template <typename T>
43 constexpr int ftei_module_constexpr() { return f(); } // ERROR
44 template int ftei_module_constexpr<int>();

```

§ 2.2.3. Examples with class member functions

```

1 export module M;
2
3 static constexpr int f() { return 0; }

```

...

```

47 namespace {
48 struct c_internal {
49     int mf();
50     int mf_internal_inline() { return f(); } // OK
51 };
52 int c_internal::mf() { return f(); } // OK
53 } // namespace
54
55 struct c_module {
56     int mf_module();
57     int mf_module_inline() { return f(); } // ERROR
58 };
59 int c_module::mf_module() { return f(); } // OK
60
61 export struct c_exported {
62     int mf_exported();
63     int mf_exported_inline() { return f(); } // ERROR
64 };
65 int c_exported::mf_exported() { return f(); } // OK

```

§ 2.2.4. Examples with class template member functions

```

1 export module M;
2
3 static constexpr int f() { return 0; }

```

...

```

68 namespace {
69 template <typename T> struct ct_internal {
70     int ct_mf();
71     int ct_mf_internal_inline() { return f(); } // OK
72 };
73 template <typename T>
74 int ct_internal<T>::ct_mf() { return f(); } // OK
75 }
76
77 template <typename T> struct ct_module {
78     int ct_mf_module();
79     int ct_mf_module_inline() { return f(); } // ERROR
80 };
81 template <typename T>
82 int ct_module<T>::ct_mf_module() { return f(); } // ERROR
83
84 export template <typename T> struct ct_exported {
85     int ct_mf_exported();
86     int ct_mf_exported_inline() { return f(); } // ERROR
87 };
88 template <typename T>
89 int ct_exported<T>::ct_mf_exported() { return f(); } // ERROR
90
91 export template <typename T> struct ctei_exported {
92     int ctei_mf_exported();
93     int ctei_mf_exported_inline() { return f(); } // ERROR
94 };
95 template <typename T>
96 int ctei_exported<T>::ctei_mf_exported() { return f(); } // OK for int
97 export extern template struct ctei_exported<int>;

```

§ 2.2.5. Examples with variables

```

1 export module M;
2
3 static constexpr int f() { return 0; }

```

...


```

100 static int v_internal = f(); // OK
101      int v_module     = f(); // OK
102 export int v_exported = f(); // OK
103
104 static inline int v_internal_inline = f(); // OK
105      inline int v_module_inline    = f(); // ERROR
106 export inline int v_exported_inline = f(); // ERROR
107
108 struct c_sdm_module {
109     static int sdm_module;
110     static constexpr int sdm_module_constexpr = f(); // ERROR
111 };
112 int c_sdm_module::sdm_module = f(); // OK

```

Note: variable templates follow identical patterns as function templates.

§ 2.2.6. Examples with lambdas

```

1 export module M;
2
3 static constexpr int f() { return 0; }

```

...

```

116 // Note that this function is not inline, but the lambda's call operator
117 // inline and that type becomes exported as the return type.
118 export auto f_exported_lambda() { return [] { return f(); }; } // ERROR

```

§ 2.2.7. Examples with string literals

```

1 export module M;
2
3 static constexpr int f() { return 0; }

```

...

```
122 // As OK after this change as before -- the addresses are never stable.  
123 export inline const char *f_exported_string_literal() { return ""; } //
```

§ 2.2.8. Examples with function local classes

```
1 export module M;  
2  
3 static constexpr int f() { return 0; }
```

...

```
126 static int flc_internal() {
127     struct lc_internal {
128         int lc_mf_internal() { return f(); } // OK
129     };
130     return lc_internal().lc_mf_internal();
131 }
132
133 int flc_module() {
134     struct lc_module {
135         int lc_mf_module() { return f(); } // OK
136     };
137     return lc_module().lc_mf_module();
138 }
139
140 export int flc_exported() {
141     struct lc_exported {
142         int lc_mf_exported() { return f(); } // OK
143     };
144     return lc_exported().lc_mf_exported();
145 }
146
147 static inline int flc_internal_inline() {
148     struct lc_internal_inline {
149         int lc_mf_internal_inline() { return f(); } // OK
150     };
151     return lc_internal_inline().lc_mf_internal_inline();
152 }
153
154 inline int flc_module_inline() {
155     struct lc_module_inline {
156         int lc_mf_module_inline() { return f(); } // ERROR
157     };
158     return lc_module_inline().lc_mf_module_inline();
159 }
160
161 export inline int flc_exported_inline() {
162     struct lc_exported_inline {
163         int lc_mf_exported_inline() { return f(); } // ERROR
164     };
165     return lc_exported_inline().lc_mf_exported_inline();
166 }
```

§ 2.2.9. Examples to illustrate complex template cases

First, we need a module with some interesting internal names:

```
1  module M;
2
3  namespace {
4  struct t_internal {};
5  void                                overload_internal(int) {}
6  void                                overload_internal(t_internal) {}
7  template <typename T> void template_internal(T) {}
8  } // namespace
9
10 export template <typename T> void f_exported_template() {
11     static_cast<void>(T()); // OK
12 }
13
14 export template <typename T> void f_exported_template_non_dep_overload() {
15     overload_internal(0); // Depends on instantiation
16 }
17
18 export template <typename T> void f_exported_template_dep_overload() {
19     overload_internal(T()); // Depends on instantiation
20 }
21
22 export template <typename T> void f_exported_template_non_dep_template() {
23     template_internal(0); // Depends on instantiation
24 }
25
26 export template <typename T> void f_exported_template_dep_template() {
27     template_internal(T()); // Depends on instantiation
28 }
29
30 export template <typename T>
31 void f_exported_template_non_inst_non_dep_overload_() {
32     if constexpr (sizeof(T) == 4)
33         overload_internal(0); // Depends on instantiation
34 }
```

Now let's consider what happens with implicit instantiations within the module:

```

50 static void instantiate_with_internal_types() {
51     f_exported_template<t_internal>(); // OK
52     f_exported_template_non_dep_overload<t_internal>(); // OK
53     f_exported_template_dep_overload<t_internal>(); // OK
54     f_exported_template_non_dep_template<t_internal>(); // OK
55     f_exported_template_dep_template<t_internal>(); // OK
56     f_exported_template_non_inst_non_dep_overload<t_internal>(); // OK
57 }
58
59 static void instantiate() {
60     f_exported_template<int>(); // OK
61     f_exported_template_non_dep_overload<int>(); // ERROR
62     f_exported_template_dep_overload<int>(); // ERROR
63     f_exported_template_non_dep_template<int>(); // ERROR
64     f_exported_template_dep_template<int>(); // ERROR
65     f_exported_template_non_inst_non_dep_overload<char>(); // OK
66     f_exported_template_non_inst_non_dep_overload<int>(); // ERROR
67 }

```

And what happens in an importing module (with the "OK" instantiations above or without):

```

1  module M2;
2  import M;
3
4  namespace {
5  struct t2_internal {};
6  void overload_internal(int) {}
7  void overload_internal(float) {}
8  void overload_internal(t2_internal) {}
9  } // namespace
10
11 static void re_instantiate() {
12     f_exported_template<int>(); // OK
13     f_exported_template_non_dep_overload<int>(); // ERROR
14     f_exported_template_dep_overload<int>(); // ERROR
15     f_exported_template_non_inst_non_dep_overload<char>(); // OK
16     f_exported_template_non_inst_non_dep_overload<int>(); // ERROR
17 }
18
19 static void new_instantiate() {
20     f_exported_template<t2_internal>(); // OK
21     f_exported_template_non_dep_overload<t2_internal>(); // ERROR
22     f_exported_template_dep_overload<t2_internal>(); // OK
23     f_exported_template_non_inst_non_dep_overload<t2_internal>(); // OK
24
25     f_exported_template<float>(); // OK
26     f_exported_template_non_dep_overload<float>(); // ERROR
27     f_exported_template_dep_overload<float>(); // ERROR
28     f_exported_template_non_inst_non_dep_overload<signed char>(); // OK
29     f_exported_template_non_inst_non_dep_overload<float>(); // ERROR
30 }

```

§ 2.2.10. Examples to illustrate complex template cases with explicit instantiations

We use the same initial setup as first:

```

1  module M;
2
3  namespace {
4  struct t_internal {};
5  void                                overload_internal(int) {}
6  void                                overload_internal(t_internal) {}
7  template <typename T> void template_internal(T) {}
8  } // namespace
9
10 export template <typename T> void f_exported_template() {
11     static_cast<void>(T()); // OK
12 }
13
14 export template <typename T> void f_exported_template_non_dep_overload()
15     overload_internal(0); // Depends on instantiation
16 }
17
18 export template <typename T> void f_exported_template_dep_overload() {
19     overload_internal(T()); // Depends on instantiation
20 }
21
22 export template <typename T> void f_exported_template_non_dep_template()
23     template_internal(0); // Depends on instantiation
24 }
25
26 export template <typename T> void f_exported_template_dep_template() {
27     template_internal(T()); // Depends on instantiation
28 }
29
30 export template <typename T>
31 void f_exported_template_non_inst_non_dep_overload_() {
32     if constexpr (sizeof(T) == 4)
33         overload_internal(0); // Depends on instantiation
34 }

```

But this time we use explicit instantiations in the module:

```

50 template f_exported_template<t_internal>(); //
51 template f_exported_template_non_dep_overload<t_internal>(); //
52 template f_exported_template_dep_overload<t_internal>(); //
53 template f_exported_template_non_dep_template<t_internal>(); //
54 template f_exported_template_dep_template<t_internal>(); //
55 template f_exported_template_non_inst_non_dep_overload<t_internal>(); //
56
57 template f_exported_template<int>(); // OK
58 template f_exported_template_non_dep_overload<int>(); // OK
59 template f_exported_template_dep_overload<int>(); // OK
60 template f_exported_template_non_dep_template<int>(); // OK
61 template f_exported_template_dep_template<int>(); // OK
62 template f_exported_template_non_inst_non_dep_overload<char>(); // OK
63 template f_exported_template_non_inst_non_dep_overload<int>(); // OK

```

And in the presence of these instantiations in the module, an importing module:

```

1  module M2;
2  import M;
3
4  export struct t2_external {};
5  namespace {
6  struct t2_internal {};
7  void overload_internal(int) {}
8  void overload_internal(float) {}
9  void overload_internal(t2_internal) {}
10 void overload_internal(t2_external) {}
11 } // namespace
12
13 static void re_instantiate() {
14     f_exported_template<int>(); // OK
15     f_exported_template_non_dep_overload<int>(); // OK
16     f_exported_template_dep_overload<int>(); // OK
17     f_exported_template_non_inst_non_dep_overload<char>(); // OK
18     f_exported_template_non_inst_non_dep_overload<int>(); // OK
19 }

```

But implicit instantiations that don't match the explicit instantiations match the behavior without any explicit instantiations:


```

25 static void new_instantiate() {
26     f_exported_template<t2_internal>(); // OK
27     f_exported_template_non_dep_overload<t2_internal>(); // ERROR
28     f_exported_template_dep_overload<t2_internal>(); // OK
29     f_exported_template_dep_overload<t2_external>(); // ERROR
30     f_exported_template_non_inst_non_dep_overload<t2_internal>(); // OK
31
32     f_exported_template<float>(); // OK
33     f_exported_template_non_dep_overload<float>(); // ERROR
34     f_exported_template_dep_overload<float>(); // ERROR
35     f_exported_template_non_inst_non_dep_overload<signed char>(); // OK
36     f_exported_template_non_inst_non_dep_overload<float>(); // ERROR
37 }

```

If the importing module (M2) uses *explicit* instantiations instead, the M2-internal components start working again, but the rest remains the same.

```

25 template void f_exported_template<t2_internal>(); // OK
26 template void f_exported_template_non_dep_overload<t2_internal>(); // ERROR
27 template void f_exported_template_dep_overload<t2_internal>(); // OK
28 template void f_exported_template_dep_overload<t2_external>(); // OK
29 template
30 void f_exported_template_non_inst_non_dep_overload<t2_internal>(); // OK
31
32 template void f_exported_template<float>(); // OK
33 template void f_exported_template_non_dep_overload<float>(); // ERROR
34 template void f_exported_template_dep_overload<float>(); // ERROR
35 template
36 void f_exported_template_non_inst_non_dep_overload<signed char>(); // OK
37 template
38 void f_exported_template_non_inst_non_dep_overload<float>(); // ERROR

```

§ 2.3. Enforcing and Diagnosing the Restriction

We believe this restriction can be checked and enforced immediately for all non-templated contexts. For templated contexts, the restriction can be checked at the end of the translation unit in the vast majority of cases. In the case of a templated context where there are explicit instantiations with the TU (or potentially some other obscure corner cases), the error will need to be deferred to instantiation.

However, in those cases *all* instantiations outside of the TU will require this diagnostic, allowing for extremely simple implementation strategies. Implementations could simply emit deleted definitions rather than the problematic ones, although a higher quality implementation would be likely (including information to produce a good diagnostics).

§ 2.4. Addressing [p1395r0] Issues With Linkage Promotion and Partitions

The problems raised in [p1395r0] fundamentally arise from attempting to do linkage promotion and organizing the code of a module within partitions. Names with internal linkage or no linkage may *require* that property, and promoting them conflicts with this. With this proposal, we preclude linkage promotion, which precludes the issues in this paper.

§ 2.5. Addressing [p1347r1] Issues With Transitively Reachable Internal Names

The problems raised in [p1347r1] are described in terms of ADL-enabled reaching of internal linkage names from exported interfaces or exported inline function definitions. While the paper's examples and presentation focused on a particular mechanism of reaching this problematic behavior that appears to be precluded by the current wording, that only precludes the discussed mechanism for arriving at the problems -- the fundamental problem remains.

Unfortunately, this means the analysis of the problem space is less complete than we would like. It requires constructing much more complex examples to explore the space, and we are still trying to complete this exploration. However, so far every example we have thought of is addressed. At worst, we expect to potentially still need a smaller and more narrow fix for any aspects of this issue that remain even in the absence of linkage promotion. All of the primary paths we have examined are addressed by this change.

§ 2.6. Non-importable Translation Units

We believe these rules are desirable even in non-importable translation units. Within those contexts, ODR-uses of internal linkage names is a common source of ODR violations in the wild. As a consequence, the rule we suggest for importable translation units can and should be consistently taught to programmers for C++ as a whole.

We propose to deprecate all of the usages that are restricted above for importable units within non-importable units to put users on notice that C++ is moving away from supporting these patterns as part of the move towards modules.

§ 2.7. Inline

We also suggest refining the *non-normative* meaning of the term *inline* for functions and variables within interface units. Currently, this is primarily associated with a hint to the optimizer to inline more aggressively. Increasingly, these hints are insufficient for peak performance and are replaced with profile guided inlining or stronger and non-semantic vendor specific hints. The hinting use case remains important, but we believe it would be better served by a separate construct that does not carry additional semantic impact and can be better tailored to the purpose of this hint.

Within interface units of modules, we suggest converging on an interpretation more firmly rooted in the semantics: an inline entity (function definition or variable initialization) is semantically incorporated into (or *inlined* into) the interface of a module. The inlined code's behavior is now *part of* the interface and not an implementation detail. Changing its behavior *changes the interface*. The module interface now includes the specific behavior of this inlined code. Using this part of the interface may enable optimizations such as inlining as well as other optimizations.

We do not think this is a meaningfully different interpretation from the reality of inline as it is used and implemented today. It does enable optimization techniques (but not the fundamental optimizations). However, it shifts to a *semantic* basis.

We see this as a first (small) step on a longer path to decouple the semantic decision of inlining an implementation into an interface from a non-semantic decision of hinting to the optimizer about the utility and importance of a particular (as-if) transformation. The remaining path toward fully arriving at this more principled end state is outlined as future work.

§ 2.8. Future Work

§ 2.8.1. Introduce a non-semantic inlining hint annotation

Currently, the `inline` specifier is used in contexts that shouldn't be restricted in their usage of internal names because it also provides a potential hint to optimizers. This hint is often weaker than desired due to its pervasive (semantic) usage. Vendors have experimented with an explicitly non-semantic hint with the ability to also be a stronger hint. We should standardize such a hint, likely as an attribute.

This should also address the other problem with the `inline` specifier being relied on for hinting to the optimizer -- often times that hint is needed on the *call* rather than the *declaration*, making a specifier completely inapplicable.

§ 2.8.2. Deprecate inline definitions of internal names

The direction of this change also suggests deprecating the usage of `inline` when declaring names with internal or no linkage. We are happy to provide a proposal to this effect if there is interest in EWG, but it should be done much more slowly and cautiously. While this is a bug-prone pattern due to the potential for ODR violations, it remains in use and we would need to carefully evaluate the impact on existing code.

§ 2.8.3. Deprecate declaring new inline entities within implementation units

The direction of this change also suggests deprecating the usage of `inline` when declaring new names within an implementation unit. We are happy to provide a proposal to this effect if there is interest in EWG, but it should be done much more slowly and cautiously. This is not an especially bug-prone pattern, but merely surprising and out of step with the semantic model. As a consequence, we again would only suggest this with an appropriately long time horizon and careful communication to users to understand and minimize negative impact.

§ 3. Alternatives

§ 3.1. Require Names in Importable Units Have Non-Internal Linkage

Rather than restricting the usage of names with internal or no linkage within importable translation units, we could simply disallow names with internal or no linkage to be declared at all within these units.

However, definitions that are TU-local are an important facility introduced by modules, and users expect to be able to leverage internal functions to factor and manage code for such definitions. We should not create barriers to moving code into modules if we can avoid it and this proposal does not seem significantly more costly to achieve.

§ 3.2. Alternative Proposed Solutions in [\[p1395r0\]](#)

There are two alternatives suggested in [\[p1395r0\]](#):

1. Unrestricted linkage promotion at the expense of restricting refactoring of module partition source that contains such promotion.
2. Unrestricted module partition refactoring at the expense of linkage promotion collisions.

Both of these are phrased as trade-offs and have significant disadvantages described in the paper.

§ 3.3. Alternative Proposed Solutions in [\[p1347r1\]](#)

One proposed solution is to simply make the internal names not visible outside of the translation unit. This has significant downsides due to causing the same code to be accepted both inside and outside of that translation unit but with different overloads selected. This at least seems prone to ODR violations as well as being deeply surprising.

Another proposed solution is to make internal names visible, but when selected by overload resolution the result be ill-formed. This avoids the risk of surprising differences at the cost of increased complexity.

§ 4. Wording

Wording is in progress by Davis Herring and Nathan Sidwell.

§ 5. Acknowledgements

These ideas were refined with help from members of EWG and other discussions including at least Mathias Stearn, Davis Herring, Michael Spencer, and Daveed Vandevoorde. For anyone I have missed, apologies, and don't hesitate to suggest an addition.

§ 6. Revision History

§ 6.1. Revision 1

Updated to remove incorrect examples and add thorough examples explaining the desired behavior for complex cases of template instantiation both within the module and within an importing module.

§ 6.2. Revision 0

Initially presented in Kona 2019.

§ References

§ Informative References

[P1347R1]

Nathan Sidwell, Davis Herring. [Modules: ADL & Internal Linkage](https://wg21.link/p1347r1). 17 January 2019. URL: <https://wg21.link/p1347r1>

[P1395R0]

Nathan Sidwell. [Modules: Partitions Are Not a Panacea](https://wg21.link/p1395r0). 18 January 2019. URL: <https://wg21.link/p1395r0>

§ Issues Index

ISSUE 1 Local class member functions appear to have no linkage even when they occur within inline functions with external (or module) linkage. This seems like a bug generally, but certainly such member functions are **not** TU-local. [↩](#)